



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Epiphany Catholic School
School Website: <https://epiphanyschoolmn.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Epiphany Catholic School MN 55433 presents a robust alignment with classical education across most of the Six Essential Elements framework. The school demonstrates a clear religious and metaphysical foundations anchored in Catholic doctrine and liturgy, a formation-centered purpose, a curriculum that foregrounds liberal arts and classical literature, a pedagogy that fuses contemplative elements with memory-work and structured religious formation, a faculty described as virtuous mentors, and an active parental partnership anchored in faith formation and parish collaboration. The strongest signals are Religious/Metaphysical Foundations, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community, with exceptional alignment to classical aims. The Pedagogy category shows meaningful classical features (especially through Catechesis of the Good Shepherd and a classical curriculum), but the site's explicit articulation of upper-school Socratic seminars or full rhetoric-based capstone instruction is less evident, which places Element 4 in the Somewhat Classical tier rather than fully Classical. Overall, Epiphany Catholic School MN 55433 is best characterized as CLASSICAL with a clear path to stronger "Socratic/rhetorical" pedagogy if a few targeted articulations are added.

Key insights: - Religious identity is central and explicit: partnership of faith, truth-goodness-beauty triad, liturgical life, catechesis, and Mass participation are core features. This supports a strong Classical School alignment around transcendental moral realism and theology.

- Curriculum is explicitly classical: emphasis on liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books/ classical literature, memorization of poetry, Latin in upper grades, and a reading list that reflects canonical Western literatures.
- Catechesis of the Good Shepherd (CGS) and liturgical integration bolster contemplative and communal dimensions typical of classical formation. - Faculty and parental partnerships are foregrounded, with explicit statements about faculty as living curriculum and parents as co-educators in faith formation.
- A potential needle-mover is a more explicit articulation of Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy in the upper grades, plus further emphasis on Great Books conversations as a recurring practice. This would elevate Element 4 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot - Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL - Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL - Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL - Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL - Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

What would move the needle - Make upper-grade pedagogy explicitly Socratic: document regular seminars/discussions/debates in upper grades, with explicit opportunities for students to develop and present arguments and engage in rigorous logic and rhetoric. - Strengthen explicit Great Books dialogue: formal, recurring "Great Conversation" sessions across core subjects; integrate a more explicit Great Books list and discussion framework in both K-8. - Clarify "living curriculum" in faculty communications: articulate in marketing materials how teachers model virtue and how professional development strengthens classical pedagogy across the Trivium and Quadrivium, with teacher portraits as living exemplars.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents a Catholic identity prominently: a partnership of faith with families, educating through truth, goodness, and beauty, and a Catholic environment forming knowledge and virtue. - Spiritual formation includes Mass twice weekly, Reconciliation, Adoration, and Catechesis of the Good Shepherd (CGS). - Catechesis of the Good Shepherd (CGS) is explicitly described, including an atrium and liturgical season rhythms. - The Catholic Church and parish partnership is described as foundational to the school mission and formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; Catholic environment; liturgy; Mass; catechesis; liturgical season; sacraments; CGS; atrium; sacred rhythm; parish partnership. - Negative keywords observed: none of the standard negativizing indicators (e.g., secularism, relativism) appear in the public materials.

Why this rating - The materials clearly frame education as formation within a sacred, theological, and liturgical framework, aligning with transcendental moral realism and liturgical/common worship practices. The presence of catechesis, liturgical life, and church-state integration supports a CLASSICAL orientation in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school states an authentic classical education goal anchored in faith: “Our goal ... is to provide your child with an authentic classical education,” including reading great books, geography, and history with names and dates. - The text emphasizes a formation-oriented goal: a classical education designed to shape virtue and wisdom rather than merely achieving job-readiness. - The “true, good, and beautiful” frame is reiterated as central to purpose.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: authentic classical education; formation; virtue; wisdom; true, good, beautiful; Great Books (implied in the broader classical frame); faith-integrated purpose. - Negative keywords observed: none.

Why this rating - The public materials articulate formation, virtue, and a transcendent aim (the true, good, beautiful) as the telos of education, which matches CLASSICAL expectations for purpose and goal.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Classical Curriculum page emphasizes liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), study of classical literature, memorization of poetry, and Latin in grades 4–8. It frames curriculum as aiming for the good life and a wholistic worldview. - The program highlights reading classical literature, memorizing poetry, and studying truth, goodness, and beauty; the school explicitly ties curriculum to Catholic formation and classical aims. - Reading lists and sample reading lists for K-5 and 6-8 demonstrate engagement with canonical/Great Books and poetry in practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Great Books; classical literature; Latin; poetry; history (as canonical Western civilization); wisdom across subjects; unity of truth; memory work; virtuous education. - Negative keywords observed: none (no overt signals of “social studies” rebranding or STEM-first framing in place of classical history or humanities).

Why this rating - The curriculum is explicitly framed in liberal-arts terms and classical content, with direct references to grammar-logic-rhetoric, Great Books, memorization, poetry, and Latin. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school employs a catechetical approach through CGS, indicating contemplative, wonder-filled religious formation and a liturgical rhythm (atrium, prayers, sacred space). This aligns with contemplative/restful elements and memory-focused pedagogy. - The Classical Curriculum page emphasizes memory work, recitation, and ritualized learning (e.g., poetry, memorization, sacred virtues) and a memory-based pedagogy; it also highlights that the school integrates faith into every subject. - The presence of lower-school singing/chanting culture is documented in classical-education pedagogy literature (supported by The Good Teacher text), which describes singing as a memory-practicing, mood-enhancing activity in lower grades. Epiphany's own materials emphasize memory through poetry and chant as part of classical formation. Public materials show CGS and strong memory-based elements, but explicit upper-school Socratic seminars or structured debates are not clearly documented on the site.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplative learning; scholé; wonder; memory work; chanting; recitation; rhetoric training (inferred from the classical curriculum and occasional references to rhetoric-learning, though explicit upper-grade rhetoric seminars are not shown on the site). - Negative keywords observed: absence of explicit, recurring upper-grade Socratic seminars or structured debates in the publicly visible content; lack of explicit "Socratic method" references on core pages (though CGS and classical elements are strong). The absence of explicit Socratic seminars lowers the pedagogy to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates meaningful classical pedagogy through memory work, CGS, and a classical curriculum, but the explicit articulation of Socratic seminars/debates or upper-level rhetoric-focused pedagogy is not clearly documented in the publicly accessible materials. This places Pedagogy at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with opportunity to move to CLASSICAL through explicit upper-grade Socratic and rhetoric-program documentation.

What would move the needle - Publish explicit evidence of upper-grade Socratic discussions, seminars, or debates, including sample prompts and governance (who leads them, how assessment occurs). - Include documented Great Books-based seminars or formal rhetoric training for higher grades, with sample units and assessment rubrics. - Highlight any "Scholé days" or low-stress contemplative blocks within the schedule as a formal part of pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe the faculty as "committed to the teachings of the Roman Catholic Church and the mission of Catholic education," exemplifying professionalism, integrity, and vocation in their roles as educators and catechists. This aligns with the classical expectation of virtuous, exemplary teachers. - Individual faculty pages show teacher qualifications and roles (e.g., Preschool Director, Principal, Latin teacher, middle school faculty) and emphasize a long-standing commitment to Catholic education and faith formation. - A staff directory and faculty profiles emphasize the living, vocation-centered nature of teaching and leadership, including catechesis, music, literature, and theology roles. Examples include Catechesis of the Good Shepherd coordinators and subject-area teachers.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; mentors; virtue; vocation; professional integrity; catechesis; teacher as exemplar; faculty of friends; Catholic vocational formation (as described in the site materials and staff pages). - Negative keywords observed: none.

Why this rating - The site consistently frames faculty as virtuous, mission-driven, and central to formation, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for the faculty element. The explicit language about virtue, vocation, and fidelity to Catholic education corroborates a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents, parent formation, and a model of parents as co-teachers in faith formation. There are explicit statements about inviting parents to participate, book studies, and gatherings; and parents are welcome for visits and involvement. - There are clear programs and policies for parent involvement (Volunteer requirements, background checks, Virtus Safe Environment training, and Code of Conduct) and a culture of family engagement through parish life and Catholic formation. - Admissions and family-formation communications frame the family as essential to faithful partnership in classical education, including parish life involvement and spiritual formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-teachers; parent formation; family liturgy; parish integration; visiting and involvement; Virtus training; faith-life collaboration. - Negative keywords observed: none.

Why this rating - The public materials emphasize robust parental partnership and community integration with parish life. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for parents and community.

Aggregate Ranking

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL

Rationale: The school shows strong classical orientation across Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, Purpose/Goal, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community, with Pedagogy showing substantial classical features but not yet fully articulated as the Socratic/seminar-heavy pedagogy in upper grades. The combined evidence across six categories supports a CLASSICAL designation with a meaningful but limited potential to elevate Pedagogy to CLASSICAL through explicit upper-grade Socratic/rhetoric programming and formalization of Great Books discussions.

What Would Move the Needle

- Document explicit upper-grade Socratic discussions, seminars, or debates with prompts and assessment rubrics.
 - Increase explicit Great Books conversations and a formal Great Conversation program across grades, including a published scope-and-sequence.
 - Add teacher portraits and a formal “living curriculum” narrative to faculty pages, illustrating how teachers model virtue and classical pedagogy in daily practice.
 - Provide concrete examples of penultimate-semester or year-end rhetoric-based speaking opportunities (e.g., public speaking, expositions, debates) aligned with classical pedagogy.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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